

Rook Endgames That Make Sense

Keep the rook active, understand the Philidor defense, and learn the Lucena bridge.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

Players who know how the pieces move and want to make better decisions. Use a board if notation is new. Books 01-08 need no endgame theory; read Book 09 before the more demanding rook examples in Book 10.

THREE LESSONS. EACH HAS A MODEL, AN EXERCISE AND AN EXPLAINED ANSWER.

01 Coordinate the rook with the passer

P. 3

02 Philidor: hold the rank, then check behind

P. 6

03 Lucena: build a bridge against checks

P. 9

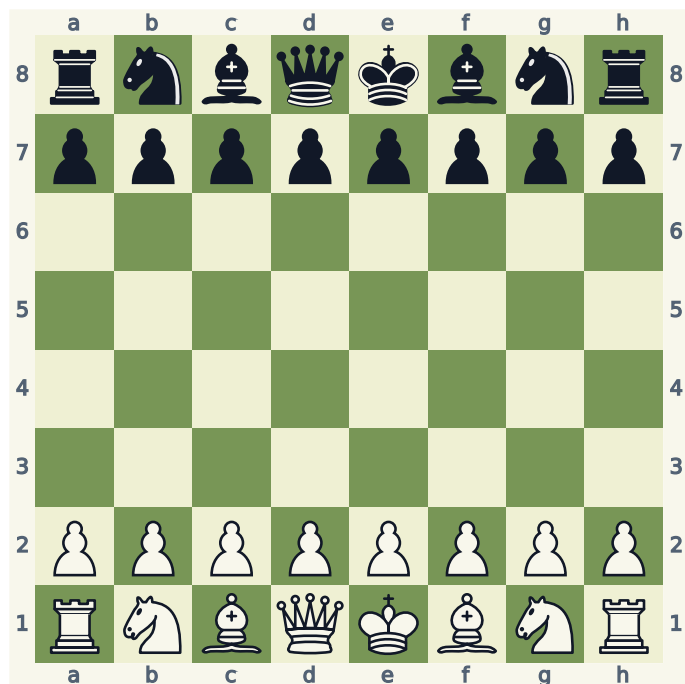
A practical study session

Spend 5 minutes reading the model, 5 minutes solving without the answer, and 5 minutes explaining the solution aloud. Spend another 5 minutes playing the position from both sides. Study one lesson per day; repeat its exercise tomorrow and a week later.

What counts as learning: name the relevant fact, show the opponent's reply, and explain what remains. A move guessed without a reason earns only partial credit. The goal is a repeatable decision, not a memorized diagram.

Use the board, then the move list

Every diagram says who moves. Boards face that player; file letters and rank numbers remain authoritative.



NOTATION YOU WILL SEE

1. K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. A pawn move has no piece letter.
2. Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. Rxc6 means a rook captures on c6.
3. + means check; # means checkmate. O-O means kingside castling. e8=Q means promotion to a queen.
4. 1... means Black moves first in that line. Read one move, make it on a board, then read the reply.

THE SAME THINKING ROUTINE IN EVERY CHAPTER

1. Check the immediate threat.
2. List two sensible candidates.
3. Test the opponent's checks, captures and threats.
4. Inspect the final board: material, king safety, piece activity and pawn structure.

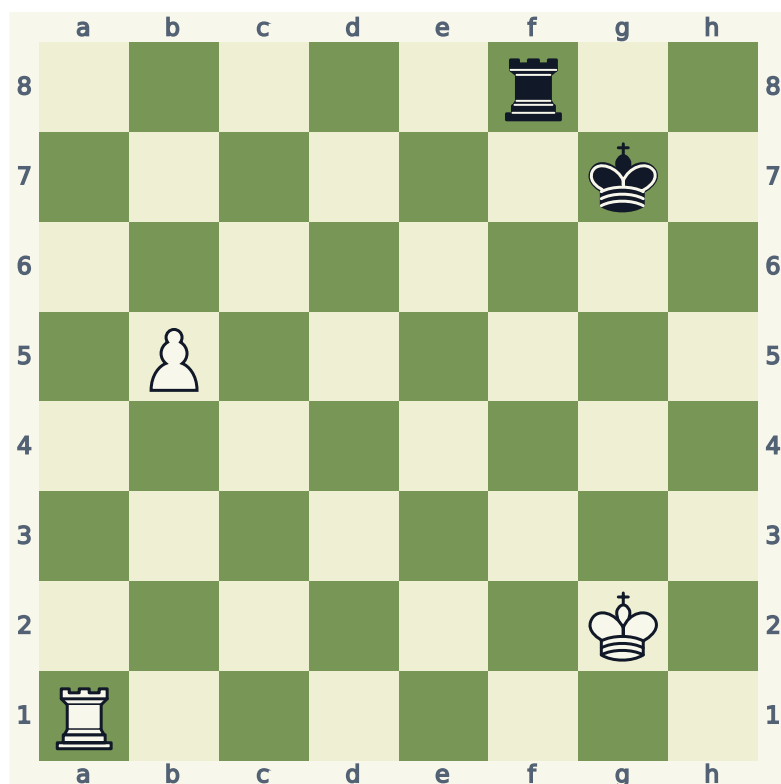
Read the claim carefully. A sample line may illustrate a plan without forcing every reply. Some exercises ask for a safe move, a legal move or a correct diagnosis rather than a unique best move. A tablebase gives an exact result for the specified small ending; an engine check supports a line but is not a proof of every strategic claim.

Replay and revisit. The web edition includes every explanation. Download its PGN file to load the model and exercise positions into a chess program; each starts from a FEN position code. No account or software is needed to read the PDF or website.

Coordinate the rook with the passer

A rook behind its own passed pawn can support the pawn as it advances. But activity, king support and the opponent's blockade determine whether the pawn can actually promote.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's passed pawn stands on b5.
2. The rook on a1 can move to b1, behind the pawn.
3. Black's rook can move to b8, in front of the pawn.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Rb1 Rb8 2. Kf3

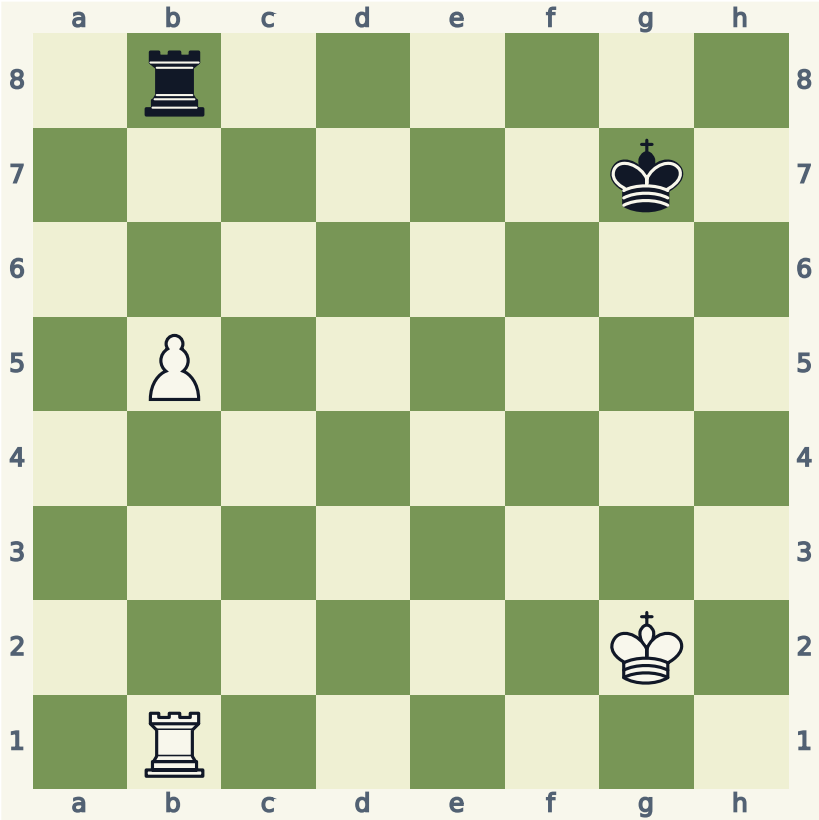
Rb1 supports the b-pawn along its file. After ...Rb8, Kf3 begins to bring the king toward the center. White should improve the cooperation of king, rook and pawn instead of pushing automatically.

Both this starting position and the sample continuation are tablebase draws with best play. The lesson demonstrates a useful arrangement, not a guarantee that an extra pawn wins. Black's active rook and timely king approach can neutralize the passer.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Can White promote immediately through Black's rook on b8?
- 2. What useful role can the white king take?
- 3. Does the sample king approach prove a forced win?

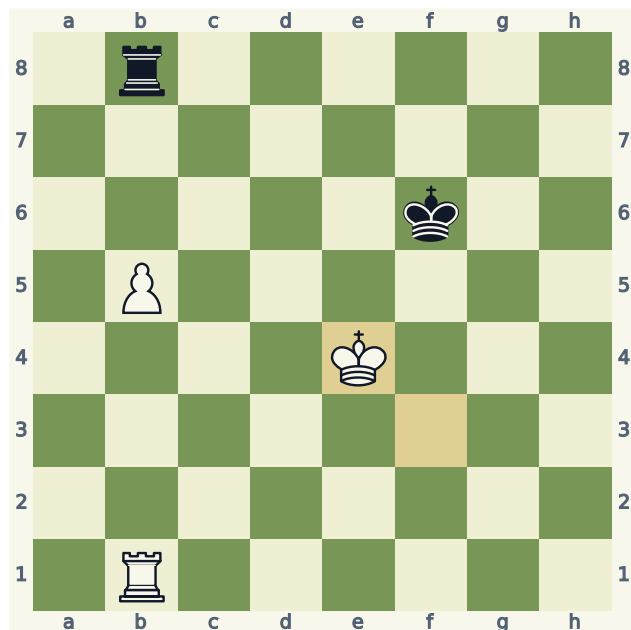
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 1r6/6k1/8/1P6/8/8/6K1/1R6 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Kf3 Kf6 2. Ke4

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. No. The black rook occupies the promotion square and blocks the file. Even after the pawn advances, White must resolve that blockade.

2. Kf3 begins centralizing the king. After ...Kf6, Ke4 moves it toward the pawn and potential contact with Black's king. The rook continues supporting the pawn from behind.

3. No. The entire sample remains drawn with correct defense. The practical goal is to coordinate and create problems while recognizing that the defender has adequate resources. Calling every extra-pawn rook ending won would teach the wrong expectations.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

"Rooks belong behind passed pawns" is a useful starting point, not an absolute rule. A rook may need to check, stop an immediate promotion, or take an undefended pawn instead.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

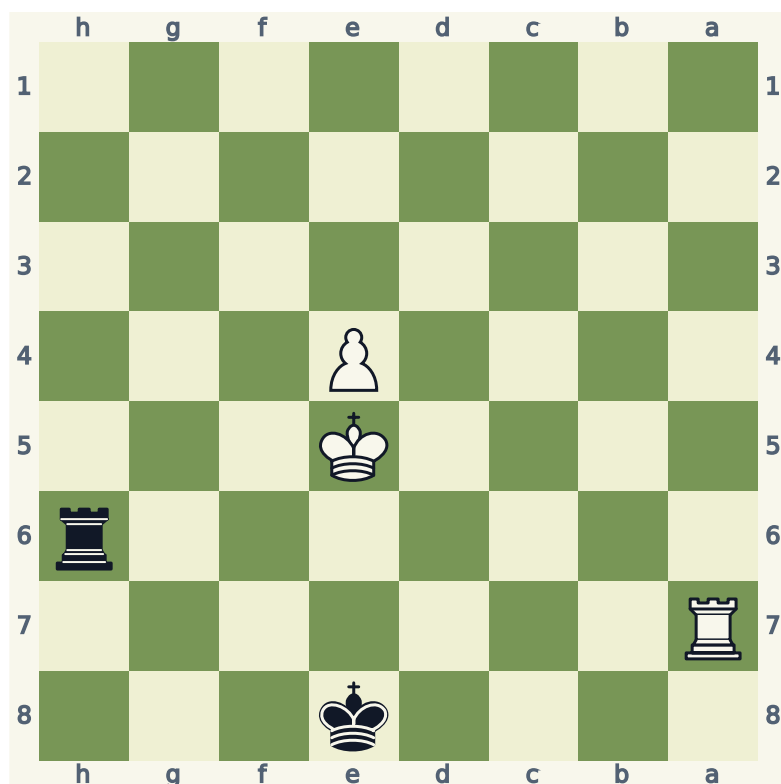
Play this position from both sides. As White, improve king support; as Black, keep the rook active and stop the king from escorting the pawn uncontested.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Philidor: hold the rank, then check behind

The Philidor defense uses two stages: deny the attacking king entry across the sixth rank, then check from behind after the pawn advances far enough to obstruct its own king's shelter.

MODEL A / BLACK TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. Black's king stands in front of the pawn on the promotion file.
2. Black's rook on h6 controls the sixth rank, keeping White's king below it.
3. The white pawn starts on e4, so Black should not abandon that barrier without checking the timing.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1... Rb6 2. Kf5 Rh6 3. e5 Rb6 4. e6 Rb1 5. Ke5 Re1+

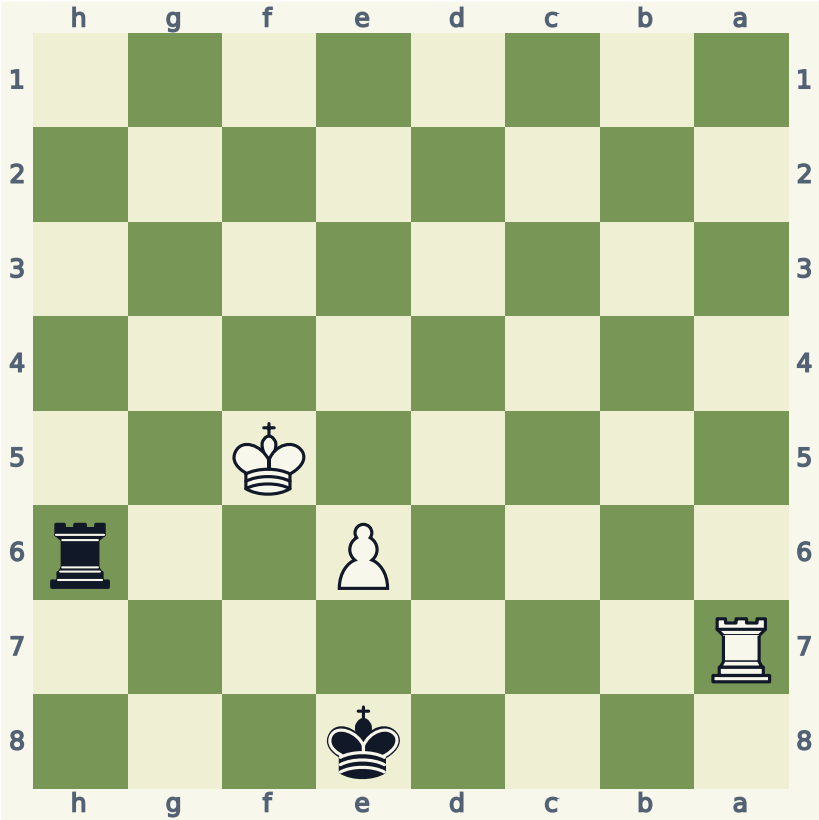
Black waits along the sixth rank: ...Rb6 Kf5 ...Rh6 e5 ...Rb6. The rook still prevents the white king from reaching the sixth rank. After e6, the pawn itself stands on that rank, and Black switches to ...Rb1.

Now Ke5 is answered by ...Re1+, checking from behind. The white pawn on e6 interferes with the king's ability to find shelter in front of it. Every step of this exact demonstration remains a tablebase draw. The timing of the switch is the main idea.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / BLACK TO MOVE



1. What important stage has already been reached by the pawn?
2. Should Black keep waiting on the sixth rank or switch to the rear-checking method?
3. Give a sample check after the white king approaches the pawn.

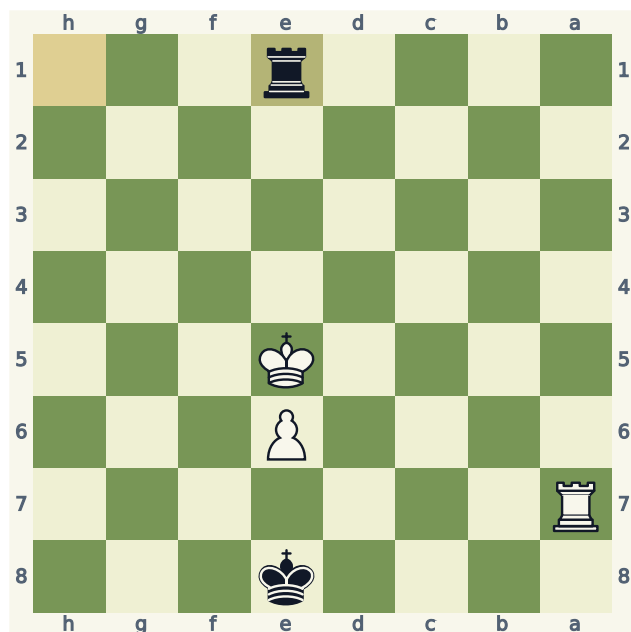
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 4k3/R7/4P2r/5K2/8/8/8/8 b - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1... Rh1 2. Ke5 Re1+

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. The pawn is already on e6. White has committed it to the sixth rank, the transition point illustrated in Model A.

2. ...Rh1 switches to the rear. It creates checking distance and prepares checks along the file of the white king. The exact position is drawn with correct defense.

3. After Ke5, ...Re1+ checks from behind. Black must continue choosing checks and king squares accurately; this short line explains the method rather than enumerating every branch of the ending. Replay it from Black's side and verify that the drawing result is maintained.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Do not abandon the sixth rank just because the pawn reaches the fifth. Premature rear checks can lose in closely related positions. Check the pawn's rank, the king's access and the rook's checking distance.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

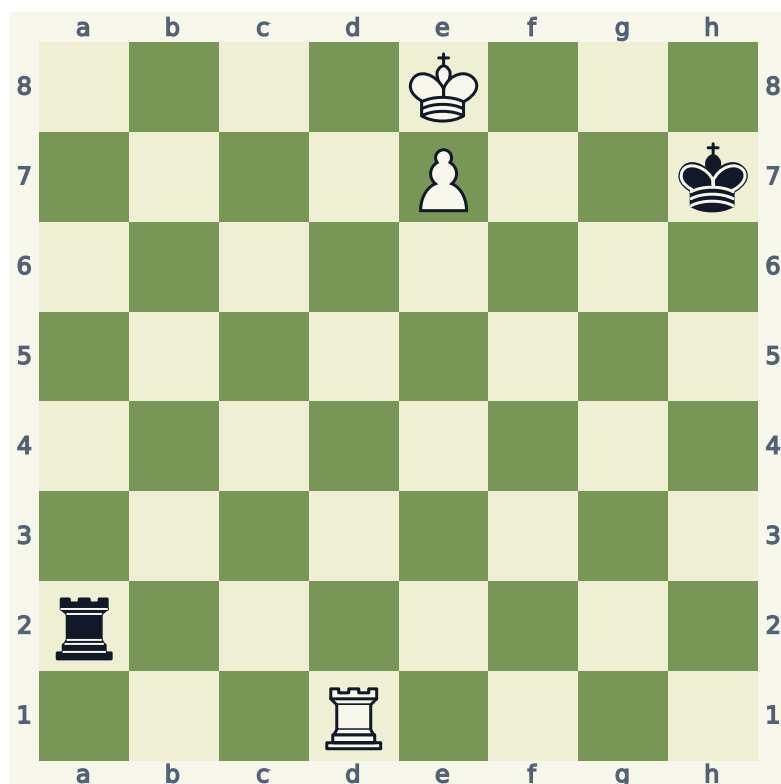
Start with the pawn on e4 and defend the sixth rank. Repeat with the pawn on e6 and switch methods. Use a tablebase to catch a switch made one move too early.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Lucena: build a bridge against checks

In the Lucena position, a pawn on the seventh rank needs its king to step away from promotion. Preparing the rook on the fourth rank lets it later block the checks and protect the king.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's king on e8 blocks its own pawn's promotion.
2. Black's king on h7 is too far away to prevent White's planned king route.
3. The white rook can prepare a shield with Rd4 before the king leaves e8.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Rd4 Ra1 2. Kf7 Rf1+ 3. Ke6 Re1+ 4. Kf6 Rf1+ 5. Kg5 Rg1+ 6. Rg4

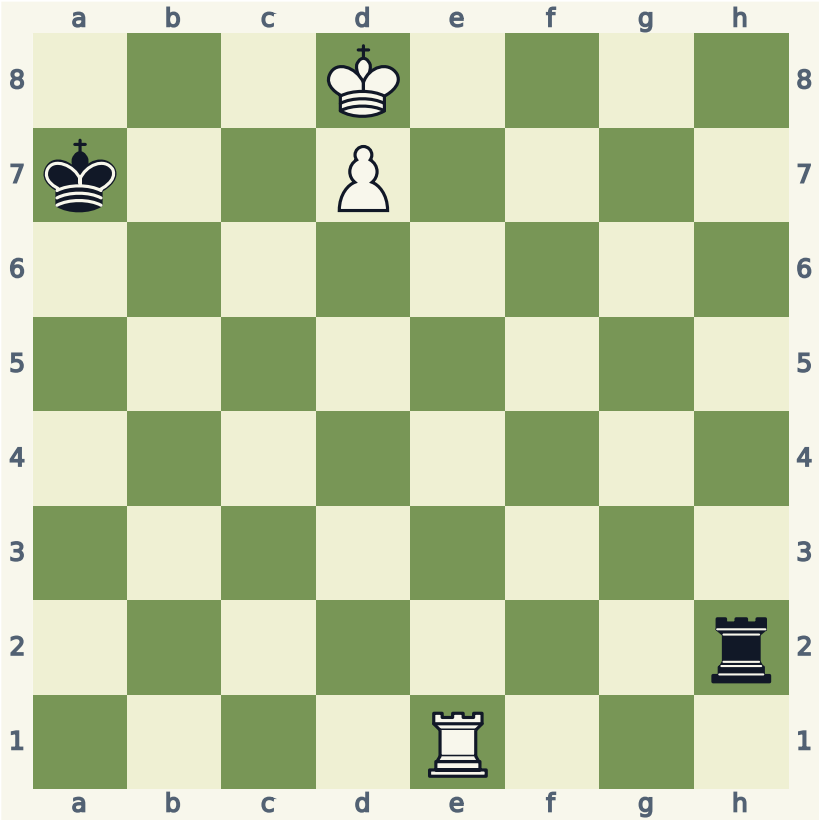
Rd4 prepares the bridge. After ...Ra1 Kf7, Black checks with ...Rf1+. White goes Ke6, meets ...Re1+ with Kf6, and answers ...Rf1+ with Kg5. Now ...Rg1+ is met by Rg4.

The king on g5 protects the blocking rook on g4. If ...Rxg4+, Kxg4 leaves a winning king-and-pawn ending; otherwise White can escape the checks and promote. The king and rook must cooperate at the final square. Every step of this demonstrated line preserves a tablebase win.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



1. Where should White place the rook before moving the king?
2. Follow the mirrored checking sequence. On which square does the rook eventually block?
3. After the block, what prevents Black from simply eliminating the rook and the pawn?

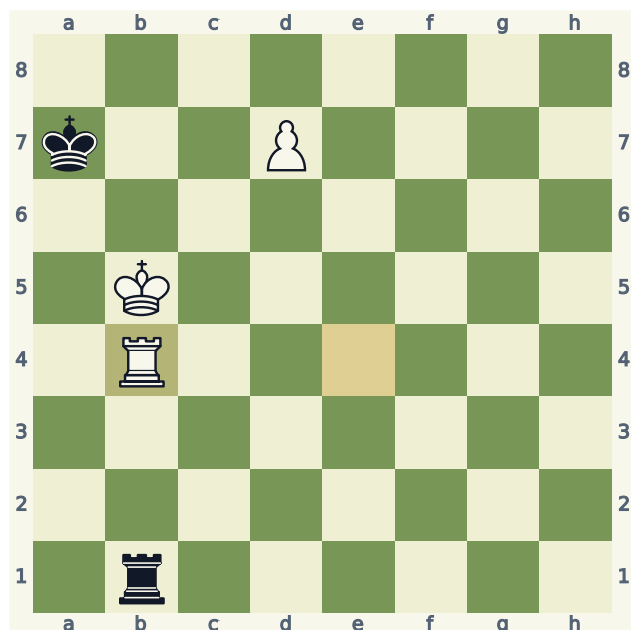
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 3K4/k2P4/8/8/8/7r/4R3 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Re4 Rh1 2. Kc7 Rc1+ 3. Kd6 Rd1+ 4. Kc6 Rc1+ 5. Kb5 Rb1+ 6. Rb4

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. Re4 prepares a fourth-rank shield. The position is the left-right mirror of Model A, so the files change while the cooperation stays the same.

2. After ...Rh1 Kc7 Rc1+ Kd6 Rd1+ Kc6 Rc1+ Kb5 Rb1+, Rb4 interposes. Work through every check on a board: the king changes file, and the defending rook follows.

3. The king on b5 protects the rook on b4. After ...Rxb4+, Kxb4 leaves a winning king-and-pawn ending. If Black keeps the rook, White has stopped the checking sequence while preserving the promotion threat. The tablebase confirms the illustrated route keeps the win throughout.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

The bridge is a response to the particular checking sequence. The defender has other legal moves, so memorize the job of the fourth-rank rook rather than assuming every opponent repeats this line.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

Replay the bridge from both sides without looking at the move list. Then choose a different black rook reply and ask which preparation still helps White escape the checks.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Remember it without the diagram

CLOSE THE BOOK. ANSWER THESE THREE QUESTIONS FROM MEMORY.

1. Why can a supported passed pawn still fail to win a rook ending?
2. What event triggers the classic Philidor switch in these diagrams?
3. Why put the rook on the fourth rank before bringing the king out?

CHECK YOUR ANSWERS AFTER YOU HAVE TRIED

1. An active defending rook and king can blockade, check, or force exchanges that hold a draw.
2. The attacking pawn reaches the sixth rank, after which the defender checks from behind.
3. It prepares a lateral block against rear checks, allowing the king and pawn to escape the checking pattern.

Checking and scope. Original teaching positions and explanations, with standard opening sequences where indicated. All 6 starting positions and listed moves in this book were checked for legality. Stockfish 19 reviewed candidates at depth 18; available positions with 7 or fewer pieces were also checked against the Lichess tablebase. Strategic examples do not claim unique best play. These AI-assisted materials are not a substitute for checking an unfamiliar continuation on a board.

PRIMARY REFERENCES AND FURTHER PRACTICE

[Lichess practice: tactics and endgames](#)

[Lichess opposition practice](#)

[Lichess basic rook endgames](#)

[Stockfish: official engine](#)

[Lichess tablebase API](#)

Edition 1.0 | 2026-09-10 | Lesson text: 1d42c4. Chess piece artwork: Colin M. L. Burnett (Cburnett), GPLv2+. Full artwork source, credits, position data and validation notes are in the repository. Report a correction with the book, lesson ID and exact move.